happy but they were also kept under control by regular indoctrination, by rotating the officers (so that none stayed in one position, and could build up opposition, for long) and by the imprisonment and execution of those suspected of disloyalty.

Repression was extended throughout Iraqi society. There were increasing reports of torture and rape of those held in prison. The **Kurds**, in the north of Iraq, lost much of their self-government and many of their leaders were executed or driven into exile. The government, dominated by Sunnis, depended increasingly on the support of the rural, Sunni areas to the north of Baghdad even though the majority of the population were Shiites in the south and centre of Iraq. These divisions, between Sunnis, Shiites and Kurds, were to become more pronounced in the years to come.

Key term

Kurds
The Kurds are Muslims but not Arab. They form about 20 per cent of the Iraqi population and are concentrated in the north of the country.

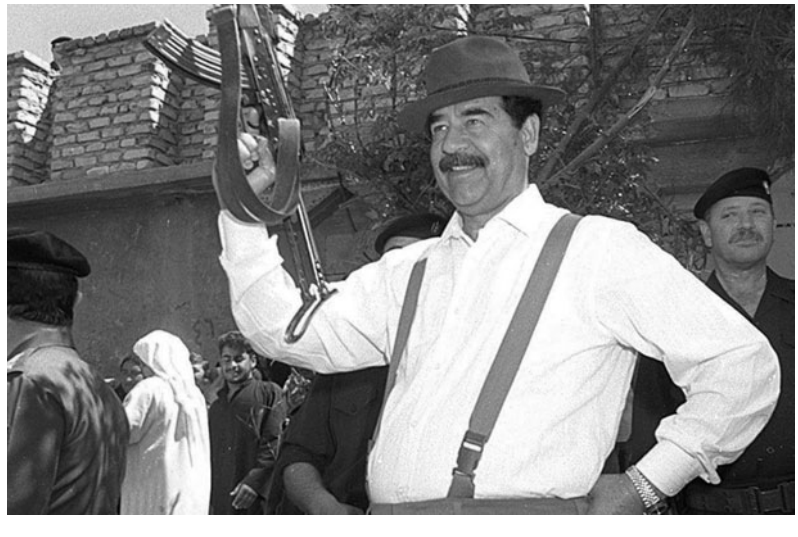
Saddam Hussein becomes President of Iraq 1979

Key question
How did Saddam Hussein's government rule Iraq?

Key date
Saddam Hussein became President of Iraq: 1979

In 1979, Saddam Hussein became President of Iraq. His presidency started with the televised trial of a number of men, 21 of whom were later executed. This was not a completely new development: for some years, members of the Baath Party, as well as opponents of the government, had been tried and executed. But Saddam was certainly showing how he meant to continue: he was an admirer of Stalin's use of terror. The death penalty became the punishment for concealing previous membership of a different political party as well as for leaving the Baath Party to join another party. There were to be many attempts to overthrow Saddam, and two major defeats in war, but he was to hold on to power for nearly 25 years.

Since the end of the monarchy in 1958, some Kurds and many Shiites had done well and become better off in Iraq as long as they proved loyal. But, under Saddam, there were mass expulsions, first of Kurds, then of Shiites. In 1980–1, 200,000 Shiites were deported to Iran as their 'loyalty was not proven'. Many of them were successful businessmen whose businesses were then handed over to the government's supporters.



Saddam Hussein: President of Iraq 1979–2003.